

Anchoring Price Experiment Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 20-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	anchoring-price-experiment

Big idea: Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students estimate values after seeing different anchors and evaluate how irrelevant numbers shape judgement.

Student Prompt

Inspect Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Anchoring Price Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can knowers fully explain their own judgements?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Can knowers fully explain their own judgements?

Setup Checklist

- Randomly distribute high-anchor and low-anchor sheets without announcing the difference.
- Use estimates where students are unlikely to know the exact answer.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value.
- Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/anchoring-price-experiment/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/anchoring-price-experiment/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/anchoring-price-experiment/visual-prompt.svg>
- Two estimate sheet versions with anchor prompts.
- Class results table comparing group averages and spread.

Run Sequence

1. Randomly give students a high-anchor or low-anchor version of the sheet.
2. Students answer whether the true value is higher or lower than the anchor.
3. Students then give their best estimate.
4. Compare average estimates across anchor groups.
5. Debrief why irrelevant numbers can influence judgement.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: What does bias reveal about human judgement?
- Can we know our own reasons for a decision?
- How do human scientists design studies to detect hidden influences?

Teacher Quick Script

- The anchor was not evidence, but it still entered the judgement.
- How could a human scientist show that the context caused a difference?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...